SpeechGeek

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It is my pleasure to welcome you to the first issue of **SpeechGeek.com**. You may be asking why would we choose a URL as our title? The answer is quite simple. Our goal is to not only use this periodical as a means of furthering forensic performance, but to also create a paper and online environment that aids students at all forensic levels. We believe our material is top quality and ready to help you begin your journey toward becoming a champion. These scripts allow both students and coaches room to be expressive and add his or her own individual ideas. We believe you should be spending your time performing, not looking for quality material. We would love to hear your comments about our first issue. Best of luck as your season begins!

Corey Alderdice
Publisher

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Canada, Eh!

by Frank and Jack Walston

NARR. We begin our story with a...story. (very spectacularish) A long time ago in a barren land filled with great wonder and delight, there lived a wee little man who loved everything around him. The trees, the earth, the cold, cold winters and everything aboot his home land. That's why you should come to Canada...because a wee little man told you to.

EXEC. Nice...I love that feeling of patriotism...yes...proud to be a Canadian. Ahem...so how did the commercial run with the test audiences?

ASST. Umm...sir...the only positive results we had were with chimpanzees and algae...

EXEC. WHY IS THAT?

ASST. Well sir it's just not appealing to any 'human' audience...

EXEC. What does this mean, eh?

ASST. Basically, primates and algae don't spend the dough so I guess the commercial is being pulled.

EXEC. We really have to do something here...I could lose my job...my car...my house...my flannel hat!!

ASST. Sir, I think I have an idea.

EXEC. Yes? Out with it.

ASST. Well while I am frequently watching American television I notice that their advertising campaigns are...well...entertaining...not boring...funny...intelligent...creative..

EXEC. I get the point. What are you saying?

ASST. (Whispers) Let's hire Americans to make our PR campaigns...that way we don't look so bad...

EXEC. OUI!!...I mean YES!! I love it. Lets get on the phone.

JOEL. Good afternoon ladies and gentlemen. On behalf of In Your Face Advertising, it is my pleasure to be here.

COREY. Thank you Joel. My name is Corey and you good people at the Canadian Ministry of Tourism have asked our firm to give your nation a public relations makeover.

JOEL. That's right. Here are the profit numbers from tourism last year. Zero (hold up a zero)

COREY. Fixable...definitely fixable

JOEL. Wait a minute. That's not right. (holds up negative one billion) Negative one billion...right.

COREY. Okay folks that's just bad-(bewildered look)

JOEL. Moving along, we have several ideas that will give your country a nice kick in the pants. So if you're ready, let's begin. We feel it's best to appeal to a new generation. It worked for Pepsi. It worked for Star Trek: The Next Generation. "N-E-X-T" Generation...see what I'm saying? Hmm...you know what I'm talking about.

COREY. You have to give kids what they want. They don't want their grandma's Canada. They want C-N-D wit duh triple A's mixed in...word.

JOEL. (aside) That means Canada.

COREY. Here's a little rap aboot a land called Canada. It's got lots of moose, but we ain't got pan-uh-das...

JOEL. (cuts off) That doesn't even make sense. What I think you were going for is, pandas?

COREY. Look I'm the one bustin' the lyrical rhymes YO! You stick to the beat ah-

Learning to Fall

by Millay McCain

I spent the better part of my childhood convincing my sister that I could turn into a unicorn at will–just not in her presence. We were both the type who wanted so badly to believe in Things Magic, I think we really did believe I spent half my time prancing about in the clouds or the heavens or wherever it is unicorns...prance. At the time, I thought there would be no end to those long, yellow Louisiana afternoons we spent being fairies, elves, dragons and every other magical creature implanted in our brains by Tolkein and Weiss. The end came in a rush of magnolia trees and hard earth. All of it ended when we tried to fly.

I didn't voluntarily wear clothes when I didn't have to until I was about twelve years old. Before that, every morning there was an all-out battle between my parents and me to don clothes in order to emerge into the less understanding world outside our home. The fight got particularly nasty when we were going to Grandma's house for, as I said, "I'll just take them off when I get there!"

On this day, I was eleven and my sister was nine. My parents had, as usual, won the clothing war; so, we were going to grandma's, forcibly stuffed into shorts and a T-shirt. Grandma's house was great because she made topnotch macaroni and Grandpa had a garden you could pick vegetables out of and the neighbor had a flock of enemy chickens.

I now feel really sorry for those poor little stupid chickens. I certainly didn't then. Immediately after getting out of the car and offering the obligatory hugs, Mattie and I retrieved our handmade bows and arrows from the garage and shot up the evil beasts with them. According to me, they were minions of the Dark Lord come to spy on we Magic-folk. Mattie (her trust in me absolutely *visible* in her disturbingly large, disturbingly dark blue eyes) rained a torrent of arrows on the miserable foul.

"Girls! Dinner! Gurehhhhls!" I looked longingly at the towering magnolia tree near the garden on the way back inside–it would be our next adventure.

"Mattie, did you know that magnolia leaves have the same dynamics as wings?"

"What's dynamics?"

"You know–it goes through the air really well. Like wings have good dynamics but bowling balls don't."

"Oh, okay."

"Well, leaves have good ones. So, if we could make wings out of them...we could actually fly."

"Nuh-uh."

"Yeah, we could–if we get high enough in the tree and then we call on the Spirits of Flight–but the wings hafta be good."

"I have an idea–hold on." She came back with a conspiratorial grin and a roll of scotch tape.

"That's perfect."

What you've got to understand is that we had been inundated with this alternative world of whimsy stuff from before we were born when our parents read us fairy tales in the womb. Eleven and nine might seem too old to believe you could fly, but we were raised on books, movies, and grandma-made costumes of the fairy bent exclusively. We went to every Renaissance Festival within a three-hundred mile radius; we watched Labyrinth every day after school for a two-month period. To us, this stuff was no joke.

So our parents and grandparents were neither surprised nor suspicious when we asked them for help attaching the magnolia leaves we'd gathered to our arms. With their bright smiles and sweet encouragement, it was clear they assumed they were helping us to merely *pretend* to fly.

"Be careful–don't mess up your wings." We climbed with meticulous precision–it took longer than our usual monkeyesque pace, but it was worth it when we both arrived at the top with a full set of undamaged feathers.

"It's pretty high" She was right. It was twenty-five feet–which was definitely pretty high...especially if you were planning on free-falling from that height with leaves taped to your arms.

"You have to believe if you want to make it."

"We can't do this–this is stupid. We are going to fall."

"–we can–we can fly–we're different from everybody else–we know what's really going on."

"Do you really think that's true?"

"Yes...yes."

"Okay." We held hands and I know we both wished, prayed, begged, dreamed, believed harder than I even have the strength to imagine anymore. And then, we jumped.

We spent the rest of the waning afternoon in the ER. One of the smaller bones in my left foot didn't quite survive the impact of the fall. Somehow it was the only physical injury either of us sustained. I spent the car ride back to grandma's trying to figure out how to explain this profound failure to Mattie. The best reason I could come up with was that we had been thwarted by our enemies: the chickens. Prospects were not good.

From everyone else, I'd gotten "Oh you poor thing" and "Let me sign your cast" – great doses of attention I usually had to work so hard for–but not from Mattie. Mattie was angry.

"YOU said we could fly but you knew we couldn't. I can't believe I believed you. And you can't turn into a unicorn either, can you? Do you think it's funny to lie to me? I trusted you so much and we fell, we fell! You made me think I could fly, okay? You did it, you tricked me; I hope it was worth it."

"I'm so sorry." And I was sorry–but not for tricking Mattie–because I hadn't meant to trick her–I was sorry we hadn't flown when we jumped out of that magnolia tree.

"I thought it was going to work." She marched out of my sight, determined not to talk to me for days. There were still pieces of tape attached to her arms.

When we fell, desperately grabbing branches on the way down, I was thinking: "I didn't really believe it, that's why this is happening."

But Mattie was thinking: "I knew it, I knew we couldn't fly. I can't believe I fell for this." So the disillusionment that happened to both of us when we hit the ground was grade-A painful: contrary to what we wished, we were not special. We were not magical, not of the Chosen Few. We would have normal lives, like everyone else. Like our parents, our friends, our cousins. We would go to school and to work. We would be happy sometimes and bored and confused most of the time. What a dramatic way to find that out. That realization, then and now, hurts something more than my feet.

As much as it pains me to say it, I think the flying incident was the end of Mattie's childhood. While she graduated to boyfriends and sleep-overs, I–even though I was older–held on to my spell-books and dragon figurines and stuffed unicorns well into middle school. Our relationship was distant during adolescence; but, in college, we grew close again. We went to parties, made fun of each other's boyfriends, tried to figure out Life and The Universe and all our Big Ideas together. Evil chickens and fairy lands and flying were old memories. We never really talked about that era of our lives.

Until last year, when our grandmother died. Mattie and I drove down together to Louisiana from Boston where we both went to college. On the way to the funeral, I found myself asking her if she remembered the day we tried to fly in grandma's backyard.

"Um...no?"

"Yeah you do–we taped magnolia leaves all up and down our arms and we jumped out of that tree by grandpa's garden, remember? I broke my foot?!"

"Oh yeah, I remember the foot getting broken, but somehow I thought that was

my foot! I don't remember anything about jumping out of the tree, though, that thing was huge! You jumped out of it?!"

"*We* did, Jean. We jumped out of the tree, trying to fly."

"We did? That's hilarious. I never remember much of that stuff–my memory starts at like...sixth grade or something. I'm sorry."

"It's no big deal."

"I do have this really distinct memory of you turning into a Unicorn in the backyard once, though. But I'm sure it must have been a dream." She laughed nervously as if she were worried about what I was going to think.

"I'd really like to think it wasn't just a dream, but..."

"Well, it wasn't to me–it sounds crazy, but I seriously remember it. You were...absolutely beautiful...and I climbed onto your back and we...flew. I mean, I know it's absurd, but...I've just decided to think it really happened...you know what I mean?"

Driving along I-10 toward what would be a surprisingly peaceful funeral, breathing the thick, mellow air of our childhood, I knew exactly what she meant.